

Hive Earth Beta Reader Supplement

Companion to the 6 October 2026 beta-reader draft

This supplement contains the reader note and the two book-style appendices that accompany the beta-reader manuscript.

Reader note

This copy includes the integrated post-Gor arc through Chapter 30. Please note where the causal chain is unclear, where a character's choice feels unearned, or where the ending's uncertainty feels confusing rather than intentional.

Please also note where Voss, Korin, Verran, and Gor feel persuasive, where their arguments become costly, and whether you ever wish one of them offered a clean take.

Appendix - Figures of the Turning Time

Archive Note

Human Continuity Archive, 5670 CE

Voice-Dictated Entry: Surface Age / Para-Ancient History

These accounts belong to the last centuries of surface civilization, before the Hive orders made continuity possible. The record is incomplete. Most surviving histories were preserved by the Coalition of the Willing.

Where certainty is not possible, this appendix records the shape of the dispute.

Maribel Voss

Maribel Voss was an ancient Turning Time administrator, military-political coordinator, profiteer, martyr-symbol, and one of the names that outlasted The Great Union. Her exact dates are disputed. Later accounts place her at different ages depending on what they are trying to explain.

In present story time, Voss belongs to stale public memory. The Proto-Under Hive preserves her in murals, old warnings, arguments, and inherited phrases. Most people know enough to recognize the name without stopping to explain it.

Poverty, Service, and Ascent

Start with the poverty. Everyone else did. Her loyalists treated it as a sign that she had earned what she took. Her victims saw it as a warning they had ignored. Hostile accounts used it as an explanation after she became too large to dismiss.

Voss grew up poor in the late surface age. Not the poverty later histories cleaned up. Poverty meant heat, weak schools, bad infrastructure, debt, and few ways out. When escape appeared, it looked less like opportunity than accident. The records that survive agree on very little, but they agree on the pressure.

Military service became one of those escape routes. It gave her structure to channel her intensity. It shaped, trained, and weaponized a girl who had already learned that institutions could call neglect a process and delay a policy.

Advancement brought her into elite institutional education, where she acquired formal training in warfare, engineering, and psychology. This combination is easy to admire after the fact and difficult to survive in the moment. Warfare taught her how people behave under pressure, how groups break, how command survives confusion, and how fear moves bodies. Engineering taught her that systems fail when wishes outrank load, heat, pressure, fatigue, and maintenance. Psychology taught her how ambition, shame, belonging, and necessity can be exploited before people recognize they are being governed.

Those disciplines shaped her rise. Voss could use words when they helped. She could build what was necessary when rhetoric failed. She could lead armies when persuasion expired.

She was not loyal to the poor as a class, and she was not loyal to the elite as a class. She valued ascent, competence, scale, and consequences she could measure. Voss did not rise above the class divide. She climbed through it, judged every floor of it, and found all of them wanting.

Poor communities remembered her as both escape story and betrayal because she refused to sanctify suffering. The protected classes despised her origin but needed her competence. Institutions hated her because she treated delay, procedure, and career protection as excuses for failure. Armies trusted her because she understood command without theater and gave them a reason to endure more than survival required.

This is where she differs from later system figures like Korin Tal. Korin fears what humans do with freedom. Voss despised what humans failed to become despite it. She did not believe humanity was unfit for freedom. She believed freedom had made humanity comfortable with being unfit.

Many accounts are harshest about this: she expected too much and excused nothing. She was not disappointed that people were weak. She was enraged that they had agreed to remain so.

By the end, enough people wanted her leadership because she promised not comfort, but an end to drift. She did not want obedience for its own sake. She wanted excellence. When people would not meet it willingly, she used obedience.

Administration and the Voss Effect

Voss's defenders say she took a second-tier nation-state and helped turn it into the administrative engine of The Great Union. Harsher accounts add that she made corruption work at planetary scale.

Both accounts explain part of it.

Later forensic histories describe her administration as the most corrupt in recorded surface history. Her network sat inside the industries her offices were meant to oversee. She held offshore trade interests through firms tied to fraud litigation. She controlled the second-largest offshore drilling network while holding mineral extraction assets and directing disaster reconstruction and environmental relief contracts. During the height of the Great Sorrow, she also helped form a secretive paramilitary complex built around arms manufacturing, training, and private security. Money did not merely move through shell entities; it moved through the legal channels she controlled. It disappeared in public, with signatures attached.

This was the original meaning of **the Voss Effect**: disappearance through legality. Not theft in the old simple sense. Legal transfer, authorized at every step. The record does not show simple theft. It shows money moving through relief contracts, school grants, hospital builds, mineral concessions, and security retainers. Some programs worked. Some bought loyalty. Some financed coups, assassinations, and the near collapse of planetary government.

The phrase changed because the world changed around it. Later, after the heat broke old expectations, **the Voss Effect** also meant acid rain falling through one hundred thirty-five-degree heat.

Most histories return to the contradiction. Almost every accusation against her was true, and so was much of the praise. She made corruption administratively useful. She also made obedience

planetary. Through corrupt but effective bargains, she moved the world decades closer to Type I civilization, when a species can command the energy output of its own planet.

Some Proto-Under Hive traditions preserve rumors that Voss was not quite human. Official accounts leave them unconfirmed. The surviving record does not show whether the claim began in medicine, engineering, or fear.

Thermal Infrastructure

Voss-era systems already joined large energy works to reconstruction, extraction, and relief. They made later consolidation possible without resembling it. Surviving planning from her administration does not use the equatorial concentration model, and no reliable account credits Voss with the silos that followed.

After her assassination, the fracture of The Great Union, and the later instability that included the Voss Conquest, the surviving authorities rebuilt unevenly. In the reconstruction periods that followed, they brought more of the thermal and water burden into controlled equatorial zones. The reasoning survives in fragments. Distributed installations were expensive to supply, inspect, and protect. Equatorial regions were already places of difficult heat. Concentration promised fewer systems to manage and more useful work from the heat the older systems had treated as loss.

The first complexes recovered power from high-temperature waste before releasing what remained. Over time they became the enormous structures later called silos. A mature silo was not simply a cooling plant or a tower. It joined underground Hive industry to heat collection, electrical generation, water movement, atmospheric exchange, hydrological control, and, later, planetary environmental management. The arrangement carried reconstruction through periods when smaller systems could not have done so, and remained necessary as the Hive grew around it.

Later accounts attach part of the environmental meaning of the Voss Effect to disturbances around thermal works and turbine water. The precise relation is disputed. Some records describe altered rain; others preserve changes in river life and soil that cannot be reduced to a single discharge or one season of bad weather. Later engineering checked or altered the active sources, but the affected ecologies did not resume their earlier forms. The silos remained in service.

Death and Afterlife

Folk tradition says someone once tried to shoot her at point-blank range during the height of her consolidated power. One version has the attacker shouting:

"You said you were different!"

He was killed immediately, which made his exact motive impossible to confirm. The details are disputed. In some accounts he missed. In some he did not. In others there was no gun at all, only a sentence later attached to an event.

A different phrase survives in Proto-Under Hive mural tradition:

"We were supposed to live lives!"

Coalition indexes sometimes attach it to the shooting story because one attacker is easier to file than a wider accusation. Under-Hive memory uses it less cleanly. The phrase belongs to people who claimed Voss-era necessity had turned ordinary futures into material for continuity.

Voss was later assassinated. That is one of the few stable facts, though it clarified little. After her death, The Great Union fractured. The States of the Great Angel slaughtered the Minority World-State in what later became known as the Voss Conquest. The violence was justified by the records that survived. Later rebel accounts are the only reason the event was remembered as conquest at all.

Hundreds of years afterward, the descended factions turned on one another over who represented the purest inheritance of Voss.

By Cassian Rho's era, all of this is ancient history. Voss is not an active political force. She is a stale reference with teeth left in it, a mural figure, a corruption joke, a weather phrase, and a name people still use when they want permission for what they were already prepared to do.

Appendix - The Voss Conquest

Archive Note

Human Continuity Archive, 5670 CE

Voice-Dictated Entry: Surface Age / Para-Ancient Conflict Register

These accounts belong to the last centuries of surface civilization, before the Hive orders made continuity possible. The record is incomplete. Most surviving histories were preserved by the Coalition of the Willing.

Where certainty is not possible, this appendix records the shape of the dispute.

The Voss Conquest

The Voss Conquest is the later name for the post-assassination destruction of the Minority World-State by the States of the Great Angel. Contemporary records did not call it conquest. Coalition summaries called it stabilization, correction, and preservation. Rebel accounts called it extermination.

The rebel term is not neutral. It is also harder to dismiss.

The war began after Maribel Voss was dead. That fact matters less than it should. Her assassination gave the factions something they had lacked while she lived: a corpse that could not correct them. Voss had taught them the language of scale, necessity, and civilizational survival. After her death, that language moved without her.

The Great Union did not collapse in a single break. It failed the way overlarge systems often fail: jurisdiction by jurisdiction, exception by exception, office by office. Emergency councils became provisional governments. Provisional governments became armed claims. Armed claims became states with flags, records, and prisons.

The States of the Great Angel formed out of this breakage. They were not, at first, a clean bloc. They were army commands, preservation offices, loyalist ministries, and emergency courts that discovered they could survive by agreeing on an enemy.

The Minority World-State remains difficult to define from surviving records. It was a political formation, a protected minority system, and a population category. It may also have been the last legal shelter for people marked as incompatible with Great Union continuity. The uncertainty is not an accident. Many of the records that would have clarified it were destroyed by the people who benefited from the confusion.

The early phase resembled a civil war with too many sponsors. Armies crossed borders that had stopped meaning what maps claimed. Commanders changed patrons. Cities paid one side for protection and another side not to burn them. Grain levies became military policy. Disease followed the armies because the armies carried hunger with them.

The middle phase became worse. The States of the Great Angel learned to describe civilian survival as enemy capacity. A village with food became a supply base. A clinic became a restoration cell. A school became a future command structure. Once that logic took hold, restraint became evidence of disloyalty.

Siege was the preferred instrument because siege let murder look administrative. Water was cut. Rations were priced beyond reach. Medical corridors were opened late or not at all. When cities surrendered, the rolls were checked before the gates were opened.

The phrase "to the man, woman, and child" appears first in hostile accounts. Great Angel records used softer terms: household clearance, line closure, and demographic correction. The archive preserves both vocabularies because the difference is part of the crime.

No reliable count survives. The numbers are too damaged by propaganda, missing registries, and later correction campaigns. The scale is clearer than the count. Whole districts disappear from tax records. River provinces lose names from maps. Agricultural zones show harvest gaps that last longer than a season can explain.

Proto-Under Hive murals preserve the rivers as red. Coalition summaries call this exaggeration. Surviving intake closures, disposal orders, and fishery quarantines make the denial narrow.

The religious character of the war is disputed because the surface age had already learned to launder belief through policy. The Great Angel did not need every soldier to pray. It needed them to accept that the enemy stood outside the future. That was enough. Once a population was placed outside continuity, slaughter could be filed as maintenance.

The final phase was not merely military. It was clerical, legal, and logistical. Census offices identified family lines. Security courts converted suspicion into sentence. Transport authorities moved survivors away from witnesses. The extermination did not replace administration. It used administration.

This is why later histories disagree so sharply over whether the Voss Conquest was a war, a purge, or a failed consolidation. The categories all apply. It had battles, but battles do not explain it. It had ideology, but ideology does not account for the invoices. It had grief, but grief became useful too quickly.

The Coalition of the Willing preserved the dominant record because it survived near the winning side. Its archives are extensive and compromised. They include atrocity denials, casualty ledgers, tribunal fragments, and private memoranda that say more than their authors intended.

Rebel accounts are less complete and often more accurate in their hatred. They preserve names the official records converted into numbers. They also preserve stories that cannot be verified: red rivers, sealed wells, children hidden in drainage works, whole towns answering roll call after death because clerks refused to mark them gone.

The Conquest did not end cleanly. It exhausted itself into treaties, annexations, and administrative silence. The Minority World-State was destroyed as a political shelter. Some of its people survived by changing names, entering labor blocs, or disappearing below the surface. Later Proto-Under Hive

traditions treat those survivals as the beginning of a duty: remember what the surface learned to make forgettable.

The Hive orders did not descend from the Voss Conquest alone. That would be too simple. But the Conquest left behind a lesson that later systems never fully rejected: fragmentation can kill a civilization, and unity can learn to kill in civilization's name.

By Cassian Rho's era, the Voss Conquest is old enough to be mural history, archive dispute, and inherited insult. Its practical use remains intact. When a faction wants to remove a people and still call itself necessary, it reaches for language first. The killing follows after.